LEAD NOW FOUNDATION

Building Leaders. Transforming Communities.

Human Resource Manual

2026 Edition · Version 1.0

How we recruit, support, protect and hold one another accountable — so that young people can trust the organisation that works alongside them.

Lead Now Foundation (registered as LeadNow Foundation)
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H No. 195-F, Ground Floor, Hari Nagar Ashram, New Delhi-110014 · info@leadnowfoundation.org

Document control

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Key contacts at a glance

If you need to…	Go to
Raise a work issue or concern (first step)	Your Performance Manager
Report a safeguarding concern	**Safeguarding Officer:** the CEO
Make a complaint of sexual harassment	**Internal Complaints Committee (ICC)**, presided over by the CEO (see Section 6.8)
Raise a concern confidentially (whistleblowing)	**info@leadnowfoundation.org**, monitored by the Program Lead
Raise a concern that involves the CEO	**Chair of the Board of Directors** (contact details displayed in every office and shared at induction)
Report suspected sexual abuse of a child	The Safeguarding Officer **and** the police or Special Juvenile Police Unit, as required by law (see Section 6.8)
Emergency	Police: 112 · Childline: 1098 · Women Helpline: 181

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1. Human Resources

Lead Now Foundation believes that people are its most important resource. The way we recruit, develop, support and retain our team is therefore a strategic priority, not an administrative one.

We believe that when an individual staff member grows, they are able to fulfil their potential, do their work more effectively and build their own skills and career path. That growth, in turn, strengthens the work we do with young people and communities.

Our approach to Human Resource Management (HRM) is grounded in our values. HRM is considered in every major organisational decision. It is built into all annual budgets and planning cycles, resulting in a distinct annual plan of HRM activities overseen by the CEO and reviewed by the Board of Directors.

1.1 Scope of this manual

This manual applies to all employees of Lead Now Foundation. Where stated, it also applies to volunteers, interns, consultants, members of the Board of Directors, and partners and visitors who come into contact with the young people and communities we work with. Where Indian law sets a higher standard than this manual, the law prevails.

Key HRM activities

- Recruitment, selection and induction of staff
- Defining roles and responsibilities
- Performance management
- Staff development and training
- Grievance and disciplinary procedures
- Staff retention and wellbeing
- Remuneration
- Contracts and legal obligations
- Career development

Core principles for HRM

- Prioritising young people
- Fair, equal and consistent treatment of all staff
- Internal career paths, progression and development
- A culture that encourages innovation and learning
- Participatory decision-making
- Compliance with Indian law and professional standards
- Values-led and mission-motivated staff
- Demonstrating Lead Now Foundation's mission and impact

2. Our Values and Principles

Lead Now Foundation exists to build the leadership, skills and agency of young people so that they can contribute to community transformation and positive change — not as beneficiaries, but as co-creators of their own futures. This mission drives every member of staff, volunteer and partner involved in our work.

Our values are not statements pinned to a wall. They are the decisions we make every day: how we run programmes, how we treat partners, how we spend money and how we talk about the communities we work with. They guide every policy in this manual. **Where a policy is unclear or disputed, we return to these values to guide the decision.**

01 Youth Agency

Young people lead, decide and create — not just participate.

Their voice is not a consultation mechanism. It is decision-making authority. We are accountable to young people.

WE DO

- Trust young people to lead our work and our organisation.
- Recruit our staff on potential, not simply on experience.
- Develop our people as leaders today, not tomorrow.

WE DON'T

- Treat young people as "victims", "targets for services" or "problems to be solved".
- Believe that leadership only comes from the top of the organogram.

02 Equity

We pay attention to equity — especially for those most often left behind.

Equity is not about treating everyone the same. It is about giving everyone what they need to thrive.

WE DO

- Use our resources where they are needed most.
- Make reasonable adjustments so everyone can contribute fully.
- Apply our rules and policies equally to all.

WE DON'T

- Mistake identical treatment for fair treatment.
- Tolerate discrimination of any kind, in our team or our programmes.

03 Collaboration

We build movements, not empires, with partners and peers.

No single organisation has the full answer. Working together is not a compromise; it is the strategy.

WE DO	WE DON'T
• Develop solutions as a team, and bring every voice to the table. • Invest our knowledge, tools and time in the success of youth-led and youth-serving organisations.	• Go it alone when partnership and teamwork will yield greater results. • Fight for the credit.

04 Dignity

Every person and every community deserves respect and care.

This is not performative. It shapes every word we write, every decision we make and every relationship we hold.

WE DO	WE DON'T
• Tell the stories of young people and communities with consent, accuracy and respect. • Give people the chance to succeed and to fail, and learn from both.	• Blame people who have tried their best. • Undermine the credibility of young people by acting irresponsibly or unprofessionally.

05 Systems Thinking

We look beyond quick fixes toward lasting, structural change.

The root causes of injustice are systemic. The solutions must be too.

WE DO	WE DON'T
• Set high standards, measure our impact and use our learning to improve. • Spend in line with our strategy and the long-term change we seek.	• Spend money that does not add value to our strategic plans. • Give up trying to find solutions.

3. Conditions of Employment

All staff will have a written contract of employment in accordance with applicable Indian employment law. Terms and conditions will be as consistent as possible across the organisation. Any differences must be justifiable by the needs of the role and the experience of the staff member.

3.1 Employee responsibilities

Everyone employed by Lead Now Foundation has contractual and implied responsibilities to:

- Take no action that might defraud or defame Lead Now Foundation.
- Comply with Lead Now Foundation's policies and guidelines.
- Comply with all safety regulations, and help monitor health and safety in their own workplace so that it is safe for themselves and their colleagues.
- Use and maintain equipment and other organisational property and facilities properly.
- Carry out a reasonable instruction (under protest if necessary) while any dispute about it is processed through the Grievance Procedure.
- Maintain appropriate and effective relationships with colleagues, partners and the young people and communities we work with.
- Follow absence procedures.

3.2 Disability

Lead Now Foundation will make reasonable adjustments to its working practices and conditions to accommodate a staff member who is appointed with, or who develops, a disability, in line with the Rights of Persons with Disabilities Act, 2016. What is reasonable will be judged in light of the needs of the individual and Lead Now Foundation's position as a not-for-profit organisation.

3.3 Job descriptions

Every staff member receives a job description. Performance is assessed against the job description and the objectives agreed through the performance management process. Before recruitment begins, the job description must be drafted and approved by the CEO. Consultants receive terms of reference. Together with this manual and the employment contract, the job description forms the basis of the contract of employment.

Job descriptions may vary by role, but will typically include:

1. Job title
2. Place of work
3. Reporting relationships (upwards and downwards)
4. Overall purpose and scope of the role
5. Essential skills and qualifications
6. Desirable skills and qualifications

7. A clause that other duties may be assigned on an ad hoc basis

The ad hoc duties clause must be added in good faith. Before assigning additional duties, managers should consider the person's suitability and capacity. If a significant part of a role is likely to be ad hoc, the post-holder or applicant must be told in advance. This is not an escape clause; it is an honest description of the role. A job description template is available from the CEO.

3.4 Recruitment

Safe recruitment is central to preventing abuse and keeping young people safe. Our process includes the following stages.

3.4.1 Advertisement

- All roles will be advertised on appropriate platforms to attract the most suitable candidates and to deter unsuitable ones.
- Every advertisement and job description will accurately reflect the role and its requirements, so that expectations are transparent and candidates can be screened fairly. This helps avoid appointing an unsuitable candidate.

3.4.2 Application

- Candidates will be asked to explain how their skills and experience match the job description.
- Applicants are asked to declare any criminal convictions and any pending criminal proceedings, within the limits of Indian law.
- Applicants are asked to account for any gaps in their employment history and their reasons for leaving each role.
- Where a role involves direct work with children (anyone under 18) or vulnerable adults, Lead Now Foundation will require a self-declaration and police verification (or a Police Clearance Certificate), consistent with its duties under the Protection of Children from Sexual Offences (POCSO) Act, 2012, and the Juvenile Justice (Care and Protection of Children) Act, 2015.
- Personal information collected during recruitment will be used only for that purpose and handled in line with the Digital Personal Data Protection Act, 2023.

3.4.3 Interview

- The interview will explore the candidate's motivation for, and attitudes towards, working with young people.
- At least two interviewers will be present, ideally with different areas of expertise, to build a rounded picture of the candidate and reduce the influence of unconscious bias.
- The candidate's understanding and experience of safeguarding will be assessed.
- Wherever possible, young people will be involved in the selection of staff who will work directly with them.

3.4.4 Pre-employment checks

- All candidates are subject to careful reference checks and may not start work until satisfactory references are received.

- References for candidates who will work directly with children, young people or vulnerable adults must ask explicitly about the candidate's suitability for that work.
- Where an employee, volunteer or partner will work directly with children or vulnerable adults, police verification will be completed as part of recruitment.

3.4.5 Induction

Creating a culture that protects the wellbeing of young people means embedding safeguarding from the very start of every person's journey with us. All new staff therefore receive safeguarding orientation and training as a mandatory part of induction, covering at least:

- An introduction to safeguarding
- Children, young people and vulnerable adults
- Abuse and recognising the signs of abuse
- Safeguarding in the Lead Now Foundation context
- Lead Now Foundation's Safeguarding Policy
- Roles and responsibilities, including legal reporting duties
- How to report a concern

All new starters must sign the Code of Conduct to complete induction.

3.5 Compensation and benefits

Lead Now Foundation aims to offer fair terms and conditions while managing resources prudently so that we can sustain and grow our programmes. Salary scales are reviewed periodically to remain competitive in the labour markets where we work, and all statutory entitlements under applicable Indian labour law are provided.

Our wider benefits exist to support the wellbeing of our team. We provide annual leave and flexible working arrangements where possible, and allowances so that no one is out of pocket when travelling on behalf of the organisation. We are committed to a healthy, safe and fulfilling workplace where people enjoy their work, feel safe doing it, and are empowered to create high-quality programmes with young people.

3.6 Outside employment

Staff may not take up other paid employment, or hold a direct interest in any business (other than a shareholding), without first obtaining written permission from the CEO. Permission will be refused only where there is a conflict with the interests of the organisation, and will not be unreasonably withheld. The CEO will seek permission for any outside interest from the Chair of the Board of Directors.

4. Safe Programme Design

4.1 Do no harm

Lead Now Foundation is committed to the ethical principle of “do no harm”. In some situations it may be better not to act, or to do nothing at all, than to risk causing more harm than good. Lead Now Foundation will never knowingly implement a programme that could directly or indirectly cause harm.

4.2 Residual risk

Even with rigorous mitigation, some level of risk can never be completely eliminated. Lead Now Foundation is committed to keeping that residual risk as low as reasonably practicable.

4.3 Minimum safeguarding standards for programmes

To keep residual risk as low as reasonably possible, every Lead Now Foundation programme must meet the following minimum standards:

- A safeguarding focal point is identified, with clearly defined responsibilities. The organisation’s Safeguarding Officer is the CEO; each programme may also have a designated programme focal point who reports to the CEO.
- A risk assessment is carried out covering every aspect of the programme that could directly or indirectly harm children, young people or vulnerable adults.
- Programmes are designed to limit, as far as practical, situations in which anyone working for or on behalf of Lead Now Foundation is alone or one-to-one with a child, young person or vulnerable adult.
- Consent (and, for anyone under 18, parental or guardian consent) is obtained before photographs, stories or personal information are collected or shared.

5. Dignity at Work Policy

5.1 Introduction

Lead Now Foundation is committed to a workplace free from bullying and harassment, where people work together with mutual respect, collaboration, openness, safety and equality. A breach of this policy can cause fear, stress and anxiety, and can lead to illness, accidents, absence, poor performance, resignation and other harm.

This policy applies to employees and volunteers in the workplace and at all work-related events — meetings, conferences and social events — whether in the office, at programme sites or elsewhere.

Bullying or harassment by the employer, by employees, or by non-employees such as partners, donors or other stakeholders will not be tolerated. Disciplinary action may be taken against any employee who breaches this policy. Where a non-employee is responsible, Lead Now Foundation may apply other sanctions and will expect their employer to take appropriate action.

This policy:

- Sets out the behaviours that are unacceptable; and
- Provides a clear procedure for addressing problems if they occur.

5.2 Relationships

Staff are free to develop friendships and relationships with colleagues, inside and outside work. We ask that these relationships do not negatively affect work. Any relationship that interferes with the services we provide to young people and communities will be addressed through the disciplinary process.

> **Non-negotiable**
>
> Staff must not have any sexual or physical relationship with a person under 18 years of age. It is not always easy to know a person's age; Lead Now Foundation does not accept this as an excuse.
>
> Staff must not have sexual or romantic relationships with volunteers or programme participants.

Overall, we hope staff build lasting friendships and connections, during and beyond their time with Lead Now Foundation.

5.3 Definitions of unacceptable behaviour

5.3.1 Harassment

Harassment is unwanted conduct related to a person's gender, marital status, family status, caste, race, age, religion, disability, sexual orientation, gender identity or any other personal characteristic, which could reasonably be regarded as offensive, humiliating or intimidating.

Unwanted verbal conduct includes unwelcome advances, repeated suggestions of unwanted social activities inside or outside the workplace, patronising titles or nicknames, propositions or remarks, innuendo, lewd comments, jokes, banter or abusive language about an individual's or group's characteristics.

Unwanted non-verbal conduct includes offensive graffiti, abusive or offensive gestures, leering, whistling, and offensive letters, emails, messages, pictures, posts, blogs or videos — online or offline.

5.3.2 Sexual harassment

Sexual harassment is any unwelcome verbal, non-verbal or physical conduct of a sexual nature that violates a person's dignity or creates an intimidating, hostile, degrading, humiliating or offensive environment. It includes, but is not limited to:

- Sexual gestures, comments, jokes or innuendo
- Unwelcome advances or requests for sexual favours
- Displaying or sharing sexually suggestive objects, pictures or material
- Sending suggestive or pornographic content by message, email, social media or any other means
- Unwanted physical contact — touching, groping, patting, pinching or brushing against another person's body
- Implied or explicit promises of preferential treatment, or threats of detrimental treatment, linked to sexual conduct
- Physical threats, assault or coerced sexual relations

Complaints of sexual harassment of women at the workplace are handled by the Internal Complaints Committee under the Sexual Harassment of Women at Workplace (Prevention, Prohibition and Redressal) Act, 2013 (the POSH Act). See Section 6.8. Lead Now Foundation will treat sexual harassment of any person, of any gender, with the same seriousness.

5.3.3 Workplace bullying

Workplace bullying is repeated inappropriate behaviour — direct or indirect, verbal, physical or otherwise — by one or more people against another, at work or in the course of employment, which could reasonably be regarded as undermining that person's right to dignity at work. A single incident may be an affront to dignity but is not, on its own, considered bullying. Bullying does not include reasonable management of performance, or actions justified on grounds of health, safety and welfare.

5.3.4 Victimisation

Victimisation is treating someone less favourably than others because they have made a complaint or allegation, or acted as a witness, under this or any other policy.

5.3.5 Other conduct

Any other conduct that denigrates, ridicules, threatens, intimidates or is physically abusive to an individual or group is unacceptable. These examples are not exhaustive. Some of this behaviour may amount to gross misconduct; none of it will be tolerated.

5.4 Complaints procedure

Bullying, harassment and other unacceptable behaviour can be addressed through an informal or formal process, set out in Section 6 (Positive Discipline Procedure). Complaints of sexual harassment follow the ICC process in Section 6.8. Using these processes does not remove any legal or contractual right, responsibility, obligation or remedy of the staff member or the employer.

6. Positive Discipline Procedure

Assessing, maintaining and improving conduct and performance is a shared responsibility between each Performance Manager and staff member. Performance Managers should create open communication and two-way feedback with their direct reports.

Where there is a departure from organisational policies and procedures, disciplinary action may be needed through an informal or formal process. These processes exist to correct unacceptable behaviour or conduct, and to ensure that disciplinary measures are applied fairly and consistently, after a thorough and fair investigation of the facts. Under-performance is addressed separately through the performance management process.

6.1 Principles of managing disciplinary matters

- All disciplinary matters will be taken seriously, with records kept in the personnel file.
- Complaints should be reported within six months of the incident so that a full and accurate investigation can take place. (Complaints under the POSH Act follow the statutory timelines in Section 6.8.)
- No judgement of innocence or guilt will be made until the investigation is complete and there is objective evidence on which to base conclusions.
- Every stage will be conducted thoroughly, objectively, with sensitivity and in strict confidence, respecting the rights of both the Complainant and the Person(s) Complained About. Both will have a fair and equal opportunity to be heard.
- Every effort will be made to complete the process as quickly as possible, and all parties will be told the expected timeframes.
- During the formal procedure, both the Complainant and the Person(s) Complained About may be accompanied at any stage by a work colleague or a representative.
- The purpose of an investigation is to establish whether, on the balance of probabilities, the behaviour complained of occurred.
- At any stage, either party may be granted leave with pay if this is in the interest of their wellbeing. This is a precaution and does not imply guilt.
- At any stage, either party may be transferred, after consultation with the Performance Manager and the individual concerned.
- These processes can be very stressful. Anyone seeking support at any stage will be helped, in the first instance through their Performance Manager, sensitively and in confidence.
- Where appropriate, Lead Now Foundation may seek external assistance or advice to investigate a complaint or mediate between parties.

6.2 Informal disciplinary process

Sometimes the most effective way to deal with a problem is informally. This may include, but is not limited to:

- Initial instances of poor timekeeping
- Failure to follow organisational policies and procedures

- Initial instances of unwanted behaviour (for example, abusive language)

Mediation

- The Complainant should first raise the issue with their Performance Manager. If this is not appropriate or possible, they may raise it with the CEO or another senior colleague.
- That person acts as a mediator, helping the Complainant and the Person(s) Complained About reach their own resolution.
- The key to mediation is that the parties come to their own resolution.

The informal route will not always be appropriate — for example, where the complaint is serious, where the people involved are at different levels of the organisation, or where either party prefers to go straight to the formal process. In these cases, the formal process below applies.

6.3 Formal disciplinary process

The formal process should be used immediately for serious matters, or for persistent minor matters. These include, but are not limited to:

- Fraud or attempted fraud, regardless of the amount involved
- Gross misconduct (for example, violence or inappropriate sexual relations)
- Persistent harassment, poor timekeeping, failure to follow policies and procedures, or other repeated behavioural issues

The Investigation Team

- The CEO, or a senior staff member nominated by the CEO, will act as Lead Investigator and is responsible for ensuring the formal process is properly followed.
- Where the complaint concerns the CEO, the Chair of the Board of Directors will appoint the Lead Investigator, who may be a Board member or an independent external person.
- A second member of the Investigation Team will be identified to take notes during investigation meetings.

Raising a formal complaint

- The Complainant should first raise the issue with their Performance Manager. If this is not appropriate or possible, they may raise it with the CEO, or with the Chair of the Board if it concerns the CEO.
- Once the Complainant confirms they wish to make a formal complaint, the process, possible outcomes and available support should be explained to them.
- The Lead Investigator will invite the Complainant to a meeting to discuss the complaint. The meeting will be documented, and the Complainant will review and confirm the written complaint as a full and accurate account. The written complaint should:
  - give details of the issue, including dates and times where possible;
  - state who is being complained about; and
  - name anyone who witnessed the event or issue.

Notifying the Person(s) Complained About

- In the interests of natural justice, the Person(s) Complained About will be told the nature of the complaint and invited to a meeting to discuss it. They are entitled to be accompanied by a representative.

- As a courtesy, this should be communicated verbally first and then confirmed with a written "Notice to Attend a Disciplinary Meeting", which is kept in the investigation file.

Interview with the Person(s) Complained About

The Lead Investigator will lead the interview, in which:

- The Investigation Team explains the formal process, possible outcomes and the support available.
- The Person(s) Complained About are fully informed of the complaint, taken through it, and given the opportunity to respond.
- Any points of disagreement between the parties are noted for further investigation.
- The meeting is documented, and the Person(s) Complained About review and confirm the written record as a full and accurate account of their response.
- The Person(s) Complained About may ask for clarification of the process or of their rights at any stage.

While the investigation is underway, Lead Now Foundation reserves the right to suspend the Person(s) Complained About on full pay. This does not predetermine the outcome.

Further interviews

- It may be necessary to speak to other witnesses. All witness statements will be documented, and each witness will review and confirm their statement.
- More than one interview with each party may be needed. Where accounts differ, the differences will be put to the relevant parties for their response.

Investigation findings

- Once all interviews are complete and the most accurate possible account of events has been established, the Investigation Team will meet to reach conclusions.
- An investigation report will set out the evidence for and against each element of the complaint, and will be shared with the Complainant and the Person(s) Complained About.

Determining disciplinary action

- If the complaint is not upheld, this will be recorded in the report, with a note that no further disciplinary action will be taken.
- If the complaint is upheld, the Investigation Team will discuss its recommendations with the CEO (or the Board Chair, where the CEO is involved) and agree the action to be taken, which will be recorded in the report.

Communicating the outcome

- Both parties will receive a copy of the final report and be invited to separate meetings to discuss the findings and any recommended action, using the "Meeting to Discuss Disciplinary Findings" letter. Reasonable notice will be given, and each party may be accompanied by a representative.
- At this meeting, each party may comment on the findings and recommendations before any action is taken. Their comments will be considered and recorded in the report.
- Both parties will then receive the "Conclusion of Disciplinary Investigation" letter, which explains the appeals process. If the complaint is upheld, the Performance Manager of the Person(s) Complained About will also receive a copy.

6.4 Disciplinary action

The Code of Conduct gives guidance on the level of disciplinary action that may be appropriate for different offences. It is a guide only; each case will be decided on its own facts and circumstances.

When issuing a disciplinary warning, the manager should:

- Refer to any previous discussions.
- State the problem and present the evidence.
- Give the staff member the chance to present their side.
- Explain that this is a formal warning that may lead to further action if the situation does not improve.
- Be clear about the corrective action required.
- Agree a date to review progress.
- Record what was said.

Level	What happens	Kept on file
Oral warning	The person issuing the warning records it; the staff member signs to acknowledge receipt. Any disagreement or refusal to sign is noted.	2 years
Written warning	The staff member signs the written warning to acknowledge receipt. Any disagreement or refusal to sign is noted.	3 years
Final written warning	The staff member signs the final written warning to acknowledge receipt. Any disagreement or refusal to sign is noted.	4 years

Dismissal

Lead Now Foundation sincerely hopes it will never need to dismiss a staff member. In most cases, dismissal follows persistent disciplinary offences. However, as set out in the employment contract, certain breaches of policy may lead to summary dismissal. In either case, dismissal may only take place on the following grounds, and must always be supported by a fair, thorough and conclusive investigation:

- **Conduct:** the staff member's behaviour is unacceptable.
- **Capability:** the staff member cannot meet the requirements of the role.
- **Illegality:** continuing to employ the staff member would breach a legal duty or restriction.
- **Redundancy** (not a disciplinary matter).
- **Some other substantial reason.**

Other disciplinary actions

Other measures may be considered, including suspension (with or without pay), transfer to another role or area of work, or demotion. Training, counselling, mentoring or other support may also be offered to help restore a positive working environment.

Refusal to sign

A staff member may refuse to sign a warning because they disagree with it. If so, explain that refusing to sign does not affect the validity of the warning, and offer them the option to sign with a short comment recording their disagreement. If they still refuse, ask a third party to be present when the warning is issued and to sign the disciplinary record.

6.5 Appeals

Where a complaint is upheld and disciplinary action is to be taken, the Person(s) Complained About may appeal by writing to the Lead Investigator within five working days.

- The Lead Investigator will refer the appeal to an Appeals Panel of at least two people who are more senior than the original investigators and were not involved in the investigation. Where two such people do not exist within the organisation, the Chair of the Board of Directors will constitute the panel, which may include Board members or an independent external person.
- The Appeals Panel will invite the staff member to an appeal meeting with a “Notice to Attend a Disciplinary Appeal Meeting” letter.
- The meeting and all grounds of appeal will be documented, and the staff member will review the written record.
- The panel will consider whether new evidence has come to light, and whether the original investigation was carried out incorrectly or insufficiently.
- The staff member will be invited to a formal meeting to hear the outcome, which will be documented and confirmed in an “Outcome of Disciplinary Appeal” letter.

6.6 Malicious complaints

Disciplinary action may be taken against a Complainant found to have made a malicious accusation. No action will be taken where a complaint is unfounded or unsubstantiated but was made without malicious intent.

6.7 Standard letters

The CEO maintains templates for the following letters, used throughout this procedure:

- Notice to Attend a Disciplinary Meeting
- Meeting to Discuss Disciplinary Findings
- Conclusion of Disciplinary Investigation
- Notice to Attend a Disciplinary Appeal Meeting
- Outcome of Disciplinary Appeal

6.8 Preventing Sexual Exploitation, Abuse and Harassment

Lead Now Foundation recognises the need for clear processes that empower staff and volunteers to recognise, prevent and report sexual exploitation, abuse and harassment.

Code of Conduct

All staff

- Every new staff member must sign the Code of Conduct, confirming their obligation to follow the processes that prohibit sexual exploitation and abuse.
- Signing the Code of Conduct confirms that they understand the internal reporting mechanisms and know how to report an incident.
- Staff understand that a breach of the Code of Conduct may lead to disciplinary action and/or termination.

Visitors and partners

- Any partner, delegate or external visitor must sign the Visitor Code of Conduct, which lists prohibited behaviours and the commitments they must keep while visiting any programme site or interacting with any young person, volunteer or community member associated with Lead Now Foundation.

Recognising sexual exploitation and abuse

All staff and volunteers receive mandatory safeguarding training at induction and quarterly refreshers thereafter. Every office, including field offices, must display a list of prohibited behaviours and how to report an incident of sexual exploitation and abuse, using the standard format maintained by the CEO.

Reporting a concern

- Everyone covered by this manual must take any safeguarding concern, allegation, incident or disclosure seriously, and report it in line with this section. Timely and effective action is essential, and the welfare of those affected is always the first consideration.
- Concerns must be reported promptly and in writing, using the Cause for Concern form, to the **Safeguarding Officer (the CEO)**. If this is not possible, the concern may be reported to another senior staff member the reporter feels comfortable with.
- If the CEO is implicated, or the reporter does not feel safe using the usual route, the concern may be sent to **info@leadnowfoundation.org** (monitored by the Program Lead, who will escalate it directly to the Chair of the Board of Directors) or raised directly with the Chair of the Board.
- Before submitting a written report, the reporter may seek support, guidance and advice from the Safeguarding Officer.
- Forms should be password-protected and shared strictly on a need-to-know basis. Written reports should be submitted within 24 hours of the incident or disclosure.
- It is never an individual's responsibility to investigate a safeguarding concern. No leading questions should be asked, and reports should be factual and objective, without speculation, assumption or opinion.
- Once the report is submitted, the reporter's responsibility is fulfilled, unless they are later needed as part of an investigation.

Legal duty to report child sexual abuse

Under Section 19 of the POCSO Act, 2012, anyone who knows or has reason to believe that a sexual offence against a child (anyone under 18) has been, or is likely to be, committed **must report it to the Special Juvenile Police Unit or the local police**. Failure to report is itself an offence under Section 21.

This legal duty applies to every individual and cannot be delegated. Report to the Safeguarding Officer as well — but never delay reporting to the authorities while waiting for an internal decision.

Case discussion and outcomes

A case discussion, coordinated and chaired by the Safeguarding Officer (or by the Board Chair where the CEO is implicated) and involving only relevant and necessary people, will take place as soon as possible after a report is received, and ideally within 72 hours. Decisions will be based on an assessment of the case and will take into account safeguarding principles, confidentiality, local context, legal obligations, the scope of the policy and the principle of do no harm. Possible outcomes include:

- No further action
- Internal investigation
- External investigation
- Staff suspension
- Programme suspension
- External referral or sign-posting to support services
- Notification of authorities, including mandatory reporting under the POCSO Act
- Contacting emergency services

Internal Complaints Committee (ICC)

Lead Now Foundation has constituted an Internal Complaints Committee in line with the Sexual Harassment of Women at Workplace (Prevention, Prohibition and Redressal) Act, 2013.

- The ICC is presided over by the CEO. As required by the Act, the Presiding Officer must be a woman employed at a senior level; if this requirement is not met, the Board of Directors will nominate a Presiding Officer who meets it.
- The ICC includes at least two employee members who are committed to the cause of women, or who have experience in social work or legal knowledge.
- The ICC includes one external member from a non-governmental organisation or association committed to the cause of women, or a person familiar with issues relating to sexual harassment, to guard against undue pressure or influence from senior levels.
- At least half of the ICC members are women.
- Each member serves a term of up to three years.
- If a complaint is against the Presiding Officer, that person will step aside for that case, and the Board of Directors will make alternative arrangements so that the complaint is heard impartially.

Key statutory timelines

Stage	Timeline under the POSH Act
Filing a complaint	Within 3 months of the incident (or of the last incident in a series); the ICC may extend this by a further 3 months for valid reasons
Completing the inquiry	Within 90 days
Submitting the inquiry report	Within 10 days of completing the inquiry
Annual report	Submitted by the ICC to the employer and the District Officer each year

The Act requires an ICC where an organisation has ten or more employees. Until Lead Now Foundation reaches this size, complaints may also be made to the Local Committee constituted by the District Officer, and the ICC described here will operate as Lead Now Foundation's internal mechanism.

7. Working with Partners

- Safeguarding policies and practices vary widely across organisations — in understanding, rigour and training — and these differences are compounded across different legal, social and cultural contexts.
- Such differences can threaten the safety of programmes and increase risk, both for Lead Now Foundation and for the people we work with.
- The strength of a partner's safeguarding should therefore be a key factor in deciding whether to enter a partnership. A partner due-diligence assessment, including safeguarding, will be completed before any partnership is agreed.
- Lead Now Foundation will, as far as reasonably practicable, support partners with less safeguarding experience or capacity to fulfil their responsibilities safely and effectively, and to deliver on shared goals. Strengthening youth-led and community organisations is part of how we work.

7.1 Ending a partnership

- If a prospective partner is not able to fulfil its safeguarding responsibilities, Lead Now Foundation may decide not to enter the partnership.
- If, once a partnership is established, acceptable practice is not being followed, Lead Now Foundation may end the partnership on these grounds.

8. Grievance Procedure

Managers should encourage the people they are responsible for to raise issues, questions or complaints as they arise, and should deal with them fairly and promptly. Every employee has the right to raise a grievance, to have it considered, and to receive an objective and reasonable response within a defined timeframe. Employees may be accompanied or represented at every stage. If either party cannot attend a meeting, it may be postponed for a reasonable period — normally no more than five working days.

Using the grievance procedure does not override any legal right of the individual. If disagreement continues and both parties agree, the grievance may be referred to an external third party for recommendation or decision.

All documents relating to a grievance will be held in the employee's personnel file for 12 months. The aim is to resolve every grievance as close as possible to where it began.

Every employee raising a grievance has the right to:

1. A fair hearing by their immediate manager, or by a more senior manager if the grievance is against their immediate manager;
2. Appeal to a more senior manager against the decision; and
3. Be accompanied by a colleague of their choice or an appropriate representative when raising a grievance or appealing a decision.

Step	What happens
Step I	The employee raises the matter with their immediate manager.
Step II	If not satisfied, the employee requests a meeting with a more senior manager than the one who first heard the grievance — normally the CEO. The employee may be accompanied. The outcome is recorded in writing and shared with all concerned.
Step III	If still not satisfied, or if the grievance concerns the CEO, the employee may appeal to the Chair of the Board of Directors. The employee may be accompanied. The outcome is recorded in writing and shared with all concerned.
Step IV	If no agreement is reached, the matter may be referred to an appropriate external third party. Normal work continues until the matter is fully resolved.

9. Whistleblowing Policy

9.1 Why we have a whistleblowing process

Our usual expectation is that staff raise concerns with their Performance Manager, or, if that is not possible, with another senior member of staff. We recognise that this will not always feel safe or practical, and that partial disclosures are difficult to follow up. The whistleblowing process provides a safe and confidential way to raise concerns outside the normal reporting line.

9.2 How it works

Concerns can be raised by email to **info@leadnowfoundation.org**. Disclosures received at this address are handled by the Program Lead, and access to them is restricted to the Program Lead and the person they are escalated to.

- Concerns are escalated to the CEO, unless they involve the CEO.
- Concerns that involve the CEO are escalated directly to the Chair of the Board of Directors, without reference to the CEO.
- Concerns that involve the Program Lead may be sent directly to the CEO or the Chair of the Board.

9.3 Protection for people who raise concerns

India's Whistle Blowers Protection Act, 2014 mainly covers disclosures about public servants, so its statutory protections may not extend to concerns raised within a not-for-profit company. Lead Now Foundation therefore provides its own protection to anyone who raises a concern, provided that:

- they have reasonable grounds for raising it;
- it is raised in good faith; and
- they believe the disclosure is in the interest of the organisation, the people we work with, or the public.

This protection covers concerns about breaches of our values and policies, not only breaches of law. It does not extend to deliberately malicious disclosures.

9.4 How this fits with other policies

Whistleblowing adds to the normal process for raising concerns; it does not replace it. In the first instance, staff should continue to report through their Performance Manager. The whistleblowing route is for situations where a staff member feels uncomfortable speaking to their Performance Manager, or suspects that the issue involves their reporting line or senior staff.

9.5 Malicious disclosures

Judgement will be needed to distinguish genuine mistakes from malicious behaviour. If there is evidence that a disclosure was malicious, action will be taken.

9.6 What happens once a report is received

Step	Action	Notes
1	**Log the issue**	Record the issue and the nature of the concern in the confidential incident register.
2	**Make contact**	Reply to the sender, confirm the concern will be kept confidential and that they are protected.
3	**Gather information and decide next steps**	Every case is different, but the aim is to gather as much information as possible and then decide how to proceed.

9.7 Lead Now Foundation Whistleblowing Policy

Introduction

All organisations face the risk of things going wrong, or of unknowingly harbouring poor practice. Anyone working with Lead Now Foundation who has concerns about any aspect of our work is encouraged to speak up.

Scope

This policy applies to all staff, volunteers and members of the Board of Directors. If someone outside the organisation raises a concern with you, you may report it on their behalf under this policy.

Policy statement

This policy exists so that people feel confident raising genuine and serious concerns without fear of reprisal, knowing they will be taken seriously, investigated appropriately and treated confidentially. It covers actions or omissions that you believe are illegal, or contrary to our policies, procedures or values, and that could harm Lead Now Foundation or the people we work with.

Concerns covered by this policy

You should use this policy if you have a genuine concern, on reasonable grounds, that any of the following has occurred, is occurring or is likely to occur:

- A criminal offence
- A failure to comply with a legal obligation
- A danger to anyone's health or safety
- Damage to the natural environment
- Academic or professional malpractice

- Fraud or financial irregularity
- Improper or unauthorised use of funds
- Unethical or improper conduct, or conduct that breaches Lead Now Foundation's policies, values or procedures, including improper use of authority
- Deliberate concealment of any of the above

Protection and support

Lead Now Foundation is committed to transparency and accountability. No one who raises a genuine concern in good faith under this policy will be dismissed or suffer any detriment as a result. Detriment includes unwarranted disciplinary action and victimisation. If you believe you are being treated unfairly because you raised a concern, tell your Performance Manager or write to info@leadnowfoundation.org immediately. Anyone who victimises or retaliates against a person who has raised a concern may face disciplinary action.

Confidentiality

Every effort will be made to keep the identity of the person raising a concern confidential, at least until a formal investigation is underway. If you need to take part in an investigation, the fact that you made the disclosure will, as far as reasonably possible, be kept confidential, and all reasonable steps will be taken to protect you.

To protect the investigation, you will also be expected to keep confidential the fact that you raised a concern, its nature and the identity of those involved. In some circumstances, the nature of the investigation may make it necessary to disclose your identity; if so, you will be told first.

Disclosures made in bad faith

If an investigation concludes that a concern was raised maliciously, vexatiously, in bad faith or for personal gain, the person who raised it may face disciplinary action.

How to report a concern

1. Raise your concern verbally with your Performance Manager in the first instance.
2. If you are not comfortable doing so, or believe your manager is involved, email info@leadnowfoundation.org.
3. If you are not satisfied with your Performance Manager's response, you may also email info@leadnowfoundation.org directly.
4. If your concern involves the CEO, you may write directly to the Chair of the Board of Directors.

When raising a concern, please say whether you would like your identity kept confidential. Concerns about third parties, such as suppliers or partners, should be reported in the same way; Lead Now Foundation will then contact the third party or take other appropriate action.

10. Fraud, Irregularities and Anti-Bribery

Lead Now Foundation has **zero tolerance for fraud**. As an organisation entrusted with resources by donors, CSR partners and communities, our credibility depends on every rupee being used for its intended purpose.

10.1 Definition of fraud

Fraud is the intentional distortion of financial statements or other records, by anyone inside or outside the organisation, to conceal the misappropriation of assets or otherwise for gain.

10.2 Examples of fraud

The following examples are not exhaustive:

- Claiming for services not performed (for example, overtime)
- False travel claims — journeys not made, or expenditure inflated
- Excessive or inappropriate expense claims
- Petty cash vouchers or receipts submitted with no expenditure incurred
- Selecting friends or relatives for procurement or partnerships without following proper procedures
- Misappropriation of income or donations

Fraud will result in dismissal. Lead Now Foundation will use all available means to recover funds and, where appropriate, will inform donors, partners and the relevant authorities. Other irregularities include unauthorised activity for private gain — for example, "borrowing" from petty cash, personal use of vehicles, or misuse of phones and other equipment.

10.3 Reporting protocol

All staff

- Everyone is responsible for raising concerns about suspected fraud or irregularities.
- Concerns should normally be raised immediately with the Performance Manager, verbally and then in writing.
- Where this is not possible, staff should contact the next level of seniority — the CEO — or use the whistleblowing route in Section 9.

All managers

- Managers must report any concern raised with them to the CEO.
- If the concern involves the CEO, it must be reported to the Chair of the Board of Directors.

The CEO

- The CEO is responsible for following up all concerns and for reporting them to the Board of Directors, which will ensure appropriate action is taken in line with this manual.

Protection of staff

Lead Now Foundation will protect staff from any negative consequences of reporting suspected fraud or irregularities in good faith. As far as possible without affecting the investigation, the source of the information will be kept confidential and limited in circulation.

Matters that do not need reporting

Genuine errors identified by existing controls before a payment is made do not normally need reporting. However, persistent problems — such as repeated misinterpretation of a policy — should be reported, so that the wording of the policy can be reviewed and made clearer.

10.4 Anti-bribery

Lead Now Foundation has zero tolerance for bribery or corruption by staff, volunteers, partners, agents or contractors, consistent with the Prevention of Corruption Act, 1988, and seeks to work with organisations that share this approach. We recognise that we may work in challenging or insecure environments, and we would never expect anyone to risk their life, safety or freedom to uphold this policy; any such situation must be reported to the CEO as soon as it is safe to do so.

Approval

This Human Resource Manual was approved by the Board of Directors of Lead Now Foundation and comes into effect on the date below. It will be reviewed within two years, or sooner if required by changes in law or in the organisation.

_____

Chair, Board of Directors

Name: _____ Date: _____

_____

Chief Executive Officer

Name: _____ Date: _____

Building Leaders. Transforming Communities.